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Bill Hughes & Frank Foster

Tenor saxophonist Frank Foster recently finished a nine year reign as leader of the Count Basie Orchestra. With section mate Frank Wess, he carried on the tenor sax solo tradition established by Lester Young and Buddy Tate, performing with Basie from 1953-64. His fine arranging skills were put to good use with Basie, and his charts on "Shiny Stockings" and "Down for the Count" have become standards. Frank is now devoting his time to performing with small groups and composing new music. He was recently honored at a Town Hall Celebration in New York City.

Bill Hughes has been a familiar face in the Basie trombone section for many years. Born in Dallas, Texas, his first band experience was with Andy Kirk. He recorded with Frank Wess in 1952, then joined Basie for the first time in 1954, staying until '57. His recorded solo on "Magic" is a trademark and since 1964, Bill has been a presence with the Basie Orchestra, currently holding down the bass trombone chair.

Bill and Frank were interviewed together following a concert in Schenectady, New York on March 28, 1995, by Michael Woods and Monk Rowe.

MW: We are filming some interviews with some of the United States of America's greatest jazz artists for Hamilton College. We are very privileged to have two members of the Count Basie Orchestra with us today. We have Frank Foster and Bill Hughes. My name is Mike Woods and I am a professor at Hamilton College, and my colleague, Monk Rowe, teaches saxophone also at the college. I'd like to start and ask you guys some questions about the Basie band and how it got started. Tell us how the Basie band kind of evolved out of the Benny Moten band.

BH: Yeah, well, Basie was playing the piano in that band of course. And sometime down the line, Benny died. And the guys decided they wanted to get something going, and they formed a group, I think it was a small group at that point, but they decided that they wanted Basie to do the out front thing. And that's really how he came to be the band leader. I don't think he planned that at all, but it happened that all the guys liked him, you know, so they chose him to be the front man. That's pretty generally how he got started being a band leader, of course it's a little more involved than that. But he, I guess he had the type personality that all the guys figured they could live with that, you know, in leading the band.

MR: Thought he was easy going, so he became a leader?

BH: Yeah. And he stayed that way throughout his career. He was always easy going, you know, he was always "The Chief." You'd ask him about being the band leader and he'd

MW: How did he get that nickname, "Chief?"

BH: I don't remember when that first came into play.

FF: I think that started back either in the late 50's or, yeah, it was the late 50's.

BH: Late 50's, yeah, because early 50's I'm pretty sure we weren't calling him "Chief."

FF: None of us ever called him Count.

MR: No kidding.

FF: No. People would come up to him, you know, lay people would come and say "Hello Count."

BH: We called him "Bas.'"

FF: We called him "Bas.'"

MR: Wasn't there an album, with a picture of a train, and him on the front?

BH: Yeah. "Superchief."

FF: "Superchief." Well he was called Chief long before that album came out.

MR: Yeah, okay. What was it that made, for you guys, the Basie rhythm section such a, just like the thing to strive for, something about the sound of the band. Was there something specific that those guys were doing?

FF: Well I really can't say that there was something specific that they were doing differently from anybody else, it's just the feeling that they got, and I think it started with Basie himself.

BH: Yeah, I agree.

FF: His simplistic piano style, and very understated, and a very happy feeling. When he first went to Kansas City and he heard this happy music and he fell in love with it and he wanted to be a part of it, well he, that feeling just osmosed into him and he osmosed it back.

BH: And when they finally added on Freddie Green, Basie was able to give up a lot of stuff with his left hand, and just tinkled, you know and Freddie was going on with the straight 4/4.

MW: When did Freddie join?

BH: 1937. I don't know what month it was, but he joined in 1937. A guy named John Hammond recommended that Basie go down and hear him. Did he go down to some club and hear him?

FF: I'm not sure. I thought he just recommended that he be a part of it. That's all I know.

BH: And I think at that time, was it Fess Williams that was playing?

FF: Fiddler Williams?

BH: Fiddler Williams, I'm sorry.

FF: Or it wasn't Eddie Durham, was it?

FF: Fiddler Williams— And Fiddler Williams is a very brilliant violinist.

BH: Yes he is. He is that.

FF: He really got that swing.

BH: All the way.

MW: Let me ask you both to kind of chime in on this question. You know the Basie sound is a sound that comes out of the southwest. And people say that that sound is different than the sound that was coming off the east coast or the west coast for that matter. How do you think the sound was different, or the feel, or the tunes that you played, or the way that the tunes was structured was different than the east coast, let's say.

BH: Well I think when you speak of different sounds evolving from different sections of the country, I think you have to take into account the whole, the feeling that people are giving out in that area. And music, especially this music, being a music of feeling. When those people come to play, they, all they do is like they're exhibiting those feelings that they picked up all day long. So consequently, in the southwest or wherever, if you got that southwest feeling, that's what's going to come out on the end of that horn, you know. And if you're in LA and you got that LA feeling, I think LA has always been a little laid back kind of an area, so out there the jazz has always been kind of laid back, you know. The East Coast —no, go ahead, Foss.

FF: The sophisticates were on the east coast.

BH: Yeah.

FF: That music was classy and elegant and elaborately orchestrated, and slick.

BH: That's right.

FF: So out in the southwest, like simplicity, happiness, that happy feeling sort of a carefree feeling and a looser thing, than the, just like loosening the tie as opposed to it being off.

BH: Yeah. After hours, get down.

MW: You know I want to ask you something that I seem to have noticed, and just tell me am I right? After listening to many, many, many Basie albums, there's very few tunes in minor keys. Is that right?

BH: I don't know. It seems like back in the early 50's we played quite a few minor things.

FF: Yes, in the early 50's and going back in the 40's, there were several more perhaps, than we did in the 60's and 70's and 80's, cause "Topsy" was one of them, what's that thing — "Tickle Toe?"

BH: Yeah, "Tickle Toe."

FF: "Tickle Toe" by Prez was one of them. And there was one—

MR: They still kind of sounded up, though.

MW: Yeah, they sounded happy no matter what.

BH: Yeah, well I never thought about it from that perspective but they did sound cheerful, cheerfully minor.

MR: Can you give our future viewers an idea of what a head arrangement was like? I mean how that kind of thing happened?

FF: Well a head arrangement probably started with one idea or motif if you will, that was expressed by one of the other sections, maybe the saxophones. Like for instance "Jumpin' At the Woodside." [scats] And the brass sort of punctuated the licks that came out of the saxophone section. [scats] And they interwove these things and, any section could be the source of one of these riffs or licks that was the main melodic statement of the song, and everybody else just knew how to fall in line and do something to enhance that melody.

MW: And were some of those arrangements done without being written out?

FF: Oh, totally without being written out. Definitely.

MR: That's a concept that's kind of lost now.

FF: It is.

BH: Every now and then you go, we go to play behind a singer or something, and we'll have to do what they call "set riffs." You know, you set a riff, which behind the blues is fairly simple because one guy just picks up his horn and he does something and it sounds pretty good and everybody just joins in on that. Now to emphasize the thing most times you do it in unison to start with, and then about the third or fourth chorus, guys go into a little harmonic thing on it.

MW: And you just know what, you just know how to catch your pitch off of that.

BH: Oh yeah. Oh definitely. You know exactly what —

FF: Everybody can figure out what part he's to play, depending on the position in the section, in the orchestra.

MW: So if you hear the lead alto do something and you're the second alto, you're gonna play about a third below that?

BH: Yeah, you play a third below that. You know you're going to be under him. You never go over.

FF: The first tenor or second or third under that, the second tenor, the second or third and the baritone can either double what the first alto has done, or pick some low tonic, low root sounds, that give it that heavy sound. The same thing happens in the trumpets and trombone sections.

MW: You know but that to me it seems like it would make for exciting music where the players themselves don't know everything that's going to happen when the tune starts.

BH: It has been known to build into some exciting moments, yeah. No doubt about that.

BH: It's not, like you said, it's not as prevalent now because the younger guys are not that acquainted with that kind of thing. You know they've come through schools and outfits where they don't do that much "riffing" we call it. But back during the 50's when I joined this band, and even before I joined this band, you know like you had to be able to vest up some kind of riffs in order to make the gig.

FF: Exactly. At some point or another, every now and then one would write out an arrangement. A written arrangement. And then leave space open during solo sections for riffs to be done behind solos. That's hardly done any more either. It slips my mind to do it. I'm so taken with orchestrations and textures and colors that I want to fill it up with everything that comes out of my head. But I'm going to get back to that — letting the fellas help with these head sections of written arrangements.

MR: You've kind of got to let go a little bit and let them do some of it.

FF: Yeah. Cause that's what this band did in the early days.

BH: Yeah, there were a lot of head arrangements when I first came in this band.

MR: Like where's the music, huh?

MW: Was it, when you, like if a band that does head arrangements like that, is it a lot harder for a new guy to come into the band and find his place?

FF: It depends on the new guy himself.

BH: Yeah. It depends on where he's playing from, you know? If he's sprung from Berklee College or something like that, it's going to be difficult for him, you know because he's been well versed in written music, you know? And the minute you take him away from that, you're saying what the hell is going on?

MR: There's a lot to be said for the ears, right?

FF: Definitely. You have to have an ear so that you can catch up on a riff or a lick after the first time it's played. The guy that sets the riff plays it the first time, the second time the whole section plays it. Verbatim.

MW: Let me ask you a question about this. Is this true they said that in between tunes, Basie would just start playing the piano and you wouldn't always know what tune was gonna come next?

FF: That's very true.

BH: That's right. He would just fiddle around, while he's trying to think of a tune, he might be looking you dead in the face. And you'd think he's looking — oh, he's looking at me, and he's looking abstractly, and not even thinking about what he's looking at, but thinking about what song it's gonna be. And most times he'd be humming. [humms] And then he'd think of something and he'd go into an intro, which we all knew what the intros were, you know. But it would be so smooth that the people would wonder, how the hell

FF: At some point during his meanderings we would know exactly what the tune was going to be. And some of them have similar introductions. Like "Down for the Count" had the same kind of introduction as another song that was in A flat [humms]. I don't know what it was, but there were two songs that had similar introductions, but somehow when it came time to hit letter A, you knew which song it was going to be. That was like amazing. I still can't figure that out.

MR: Now John Heard told us that his first night on the band Basie did that and he's going, he's saying "what's the tune" and one guy told him it's number 4 and one guy told him it's number 11. You guys wouldn't do that, would you? Of course but he said he couldn't read music anyway so it didn't matter.

FF: Wait a minute, you're not talking about John Heard?

MR: I think he was putting us on.

BH: John had a good time while he was here.

MW: But going back to that, when they're setting up the intros like that, and a new guy comes on the band, okay, so he maybe doesn't know this routine. Did you guys ever, when the new guy is sitting there saying "what tune is it," did you generally bail him out by helping him with what tune? Or did you sabotage him —

FF: Oh, no, he didn't even have to ask. As soon as Basie started in, as soon as it was known what tune it was, he'd say, "Corner Pocket" or whatever. The idea of sabotaging someone was taboo, because that would affect the overall sound of the band, it might displease Basie, and someone in the audience might pick it up and say "well they're not too together, are they?" So that was, even if you didn't like someone personally, the idea of sabotaging —

BH: What did happen sometimes is if Basie felt like he was taking a little long getting to what we call a "joiner," [humms] he would go into it a little fast before the guy could find the music and you're stuck trying to play your part and tell the guy next you, if he's new, you know, what number to get up. And in that case you'd see the guy scrambling, you know, and he's not able to play until he gets the part up.

FF: But it's not a sabotage thing at all.

MW: Were there other more acceptable forms of humor in the band?

FF: Well, yes, certainly. You want to start that one, Bill?

BH: Well acceptable forms of humor? Well one of the queerest things that I ever went through on the bandstand was that if you stood up to take a solo in place in this band, generally when you sat down, there was some kind of a mute or plunger or something, and you'd get this immediate goose when you sat down. That's when the house falls apart, you know. But that's just one of the things that comes to mind.

BH: Or late, especially late.

FF: My punctuality habits were horrible in those days. So I'd come in late and he would call either "Little Pony" or "Jumpin' at the Woodside" and I'd have to rise to the occasion immediately. And if something happened, my reed is too dry and I might squeak during the performance, Basie would be the first one to break up and fall off the stool laughing. And the almost embarrassing, most embarrassing thing that ever happened to me was in Manchester, it was either in Manchester or Birmingham, England, I can't remember which—

BH: Yeah, I was going to bring that up.

FF: I lost my dress shoes. We had a brown and tan tux, and I lost my brown dress shoes. Misplaced them, they weren't lost, maybe Barracuda got them or something. But anyway, by concert time, I had no dress shoes. And with this brown and tan tuxedo, I had some blue and white sneakers. So it came time for me to take a solo, a big solo. On short solos, one might stand up in front of one's stand and just play eight measures and sit down. But on long, extended solos, you always came out to the microphone. Well with these blue and white sneakers on, and this brown and tan tuxedo, I didn't want to come out to the microphone, so I tried to, I stood up at my stand and played my solo. And Charlie Fowlkes, the baritone saxophone, wouldn't have none of this, so he cooly, very cooly just pulled my bandstand out from in front of me, and thousands of people saw the fellow playing the tenor solo with brown and tan tuxedo and blue and white sneakers, and everybody in the band broke up, the audience broke up, and Basie did his usual falling off the stool.

BH: Yeah. There was another time, you remember Titus Turner?

FF: Yeah, I remember Titus Turner.

BH: Titus Turner was a singer of sorts, and he was performing with the band. And I don't know what he did to get everybody upset. But everybody was very upset at Titus. And somebody cooked up the plot: we ain't playing, you know, behind this guy. And I think Marhsall kicked off the tune, and all of a sudden everybody was just sitting there.

FF: Oh, yeah?

BH: Yeah, you don't remember that?

FF: No I don't.

BH: And everybody was just sitting there and this guy, he was so upset he started crying. And Basie was dying over there, you know?

FF: No, I don't remember his crying.

BH: The band refused to play for him. And Basie died. And he was looking at him like "I told you."

FF: There was a time in Chicago when we played, it was a Birdland show, we played at the opera house, and the concert started at 8:00. And I'd had company that afternoon at the hotel, and at 8:00 I was just waking up, and the band was playing, no Frank Foster. So I hurriedly got dressed and called a taxi down to the theater, and I had got there just in time to miss the first half. So I walked in after the intermission was over, and hurriedly got my horn out. In the meantime, the first song after intermission was a song of Neal Hefti's called "Dinner with Friends" that featured a solo break. Like I had a two measure break, and into the solo. A break is where the horn player or soloist is all by him or herself, and the rhythm section lays out, and then they start back at the beginning of the solo. So Frank Wess was getting prepared to take my solo, 'cause ostensibly I hadn't shown yet. And so when it came to this part in the song, it was going to be just before the break and sort of an interlude. [scats] And as Frank Wess was standing up ready to play, here I come walking on stage just in time to make the break.

MR: You got it.

FF: Yeah, I took it — it was my solo. So before they cursed me out, they laughed. Then then cursed me out.

MR: What was it like, was there a certain amount of competition for solo space in the band?

BH: Not amongst the trombone players. Maybe the saxophone players.

FF: Yeah, there wasn't really a feeling of competition.

MR: No?

FF: In the old days, Basie liked to keep something going like stories of Lester Young and Don Byas or Buddy Tate not liking one another, but they were all, they really loved each other. But the stories were about the rivalry going on.

BH: Well that was the thing from those days, you know, guys would purposely, you know, go out looking for a session, for one particular guy, for the cutting contests. That doesn't happen much anymore, but I mean they would take it through all sorts of things I suppose, you know, changing keys, and tunes and if you couldn't hang, you were dead. But I remember this one particular instance, we were doing a Birdland show. And I don't remember, I remember we flew up to Boston and we did the show, and then we flew right back into New York. Bird was on the show. You remember that show? You don't remember that show?

FF: I'm so ashamed that I don't remember the show Bird was on.

BH: Bird came up, unfortunately Bird didn't have a horn when he came up. So Bird borrowed the horn from, I think he borrowed Ernie Wilkins' horn, and it was something terribly out of whack with the reed as far as Bird was concerned, that Ernie was using. So every other note that Bird played that night was a squeak, you know? And I just remember being, you

MR: Probably because Bird uses a number five —

FF: Yeah, and Ernie uses number two. I think that's one I blotted out from my memory conveniently.

BH: Yeah, maybe so. That stays on my mind all the time, you know?

MW: Let me ask, what is one of the funniest or craziest predicaments that the band has gotten into as a whole since you've been with the band?

BH: Well for me it was the time that we were in Europe, we were traveling around Europe. And I don't remember where we were coming from, but we got to this hall in Paris called the Salle Pleyel. You remember the Salle Pleyel?

FF: Yeah, I remember the Salle Pleyel.

BH: Well anyway we got to the hall, unfortunately, our instruments didn't. The instruments went to —

FF: Jamaica somewhere.

BH: Yeah, somewhere in the Caribbean.

FF: It was the music wasn't it? Was it the music or the instruments? Or both?

BH: It was the music and the drums and stuff like that you know. And we obviously couldn't play. Because there were some of us, I guess the baritone saxophone and something else.

FF: Yeah, drums.

BH: So we were sitting in this hall, and the Frenchmen, you know they get very upset if things don't go according to plan. So they started to get restless and we were sitting there waiting on the music, and all of a sudden it got very loud out there, you know? And Basie said "I think we better get the hell out of here" you know. And we had to slip out a side door because we thought those people were going to attack us, you know, I don't think they believed that we didn't have any — somebody went out there and announced what had happened, but it didn't sound right to them I guess, and we had to slip out of there, and for the next five days I think we were off because we didn't have anything to work with. And that was—

FF: It took that long for the stuff to catch up with the band.

BH: Yeah.

MR: What was it like playing in Europe for the most part. Was it different from the States?

FF: It seemed so in the beginning.

BH: Yeah, during that time, I think it was definitely different.

MR: How so?

BH: Well at that time, I mean the world wasn't so accessible. Like it took us 13 hours to go over there on prop planes. We'd go up by way of Newfoundland, you know gas up up there, and then jump across the ocean on the DC-7 or what was the other, the DC-6.

BH: Yeah.

FF: Prior to 1958.

BH: Yeah. And the two cultures were like totally divided. Right now when you go over there you can't feel that much different than you do in the United States. But at that point, I mean the language and everything else was just completely different. So it made us feel like we were doing something completely different ourselves, because we were hearing all the foreign languages, and we were seeing people do things differently than they do them in the United States. We couldn't get a sandwich after about 12:00 at night. You know, it was just, it was totally different. And the women were more interesting at that point cause we were younger too. And that made a lot of difference. Don't show this to my wife, I didn't mean anything.

FF: The fans seemed to appreciate the music more. I don't know if it was actually true, but it just seemed as though larger percentages of European audiences really related to the music and back home it seemed as though lots of people would say, "well that's all right, what else can you do?"

BH: Yeah, that's true.

FF: But over the years I've found that the United States has sort of caught up as far as audience appreciation of what we do, compared to the European audiences. And even in the latter years of my tour of duty with the orchestra, in the, after '62, '63, '64, it seemed as though when we went to Europe, we'd see whole families come to concerts, but it may just have been the father who appreciated the music and the rest of the family was just there 'cause he brought them and maybe he wanted to expose them to this American cultural entity. And it seemed as though a lot of people came out of curiosity, "oh we've heard about this Count Basie Orchestra, let's see what it's about" to me. Bill may have a different story, but that's the feeling I got.

BH: No, that's pretty much the way I perceived it.

FF: In the mid-60's, and this was just prior to The Beatles striking it big, and the big beat turning things around.

BH: Let me tell you a story about The Beatles. We were in Liverpool in early 1964. And we went to this little cave-like club, you know, and I guess that was them playing. They came back later and said it was them anyhow. We were sitting there and listening to this little group play, you know? And they sounded all right, but we didn't, you know, pay that much attention. We were really there looking for something else anyhow. And Basie was there. And I remember one of those guys coming up after the set and talking to Basie, asking how he thought they sounded. He say, "yeah," you know Basie was always very nice, "you guys sound all right" you know? And I think about maybe six months

later, these guys were coming to New York taking New York by storm, you know? And I didn't realize then it was the same group.

MR: That's right they were playing The Cavern or something.

BH: But I'll tell you what they did, they were so impressed with Basie that later on down the line they got Basie to do two Beatle albums. I don't know whether you ever heard.

MR: Yes, I did.

BH: "Basie's Beatle Bag," and something else, I can't remember because we never really played the tunes after we did the album. But I remember one of the, I can't remember whether it was Lennon or somebody else came to the record date while we were doing it. But they had never forgotten that Basie had come in and said that they sounded good.

FF: Basie didn't even remember.

MR: I was going to ask you how those kind of albums came about, like I know you did one of Hollywood movie themes too.

FF: Oh, yeah, "The Apartment," etcetera, etcetera. And the James Bond— I wasn't in the band when these —

BH: We were covering everything that wasn't covered in the mid-60's, I mean like doing record dates like often. A lot of the stuff that we went into the studios and did we'd sit there and we'd rehearse it, we'd record it, and that would be the last time we'd see that music.

FF: Right.

BH: I mean those kind of throwaway dates that Basie did, and it was all in the name of money, I think at that point.

FF: Yeah, I think he was persuaded by the producers to do it, but on the gigs you never heard—

BH: No, he wouldn't play those tunes.

FF: I thought, I personally thought that the James Bond album had the wrong arranger.

BH: Who arranged that devil?

FF: I don't know. I really don't know.

MR: It wasn't you though, right?

FF: No, it wasn't me though, right. See because a lot of these things were done and it seemed as though it was hard to fit the concept of the Basie style behind these charts. And they just didn't come off. And the person who did the arranging was outside the band, of course, and didn't really know Basie's personal formula.

BH: I don't remember who recorded, I mean who wrote that album.

FF: You don't?

BH: No, I don't. I don't recall who wrote. I remember doing the album.

MW: That leads to another thought is the fact that the Basie band had a very distinct, the whole band had a very personal sound.

FF: Definitely.

MW: I want to ask you, what groups do you see existing today, if there are any, that approximate that kind of personal sound that you've come to like and enjoy in the Basie band. Are there any groups or specific artists that you think are perpetuating what jazz is really about today?

FF: Certainly.

MW: Could you name a couple of those groups?

FF: Young groups, you know like Terrance Blanchard, of course the Elvin Jones group makes use of a lot of youngsters such as Nicholas Payton and they even use Coltrane's son, Ravi Coltrane with Elvin Jones. And of course Vincent Herring, an alto saxophonist, Jesse Davis, another alto saxophonist, Bobby Watson, another alto saxophonist, Roy Hargrove, Chris McBride, Antonio Hart. These are the youngsters that are, that are carrying on authentic jazz. This is not the Basie style, now, I'm talking about small group jazz. And there are, there are many others that doing it. The Harper Brothers, they broke up as a group, but the two of them are doing like straight ahead jazz. And if you're speaking of big bands that have distinctive sounds, there are a few of those around, but your question wasn't relating to other bands doing the Basie thing.

MW: No, not necessarily doing the Basie thing, but in other words, just putting your thumb on the pulse and saying, are the traditions alive and well?

FF: Yeah, I would say the traditions are alive and well. Illinois Jacquet has a band that's a very good band, and of course he's from the old school, and the arrangements are from that same school. And a lot of the guys are in that generation, mixed with younger guys, really doing very well. And there are some bands around New York, well I don't know how you rate Toshiko Akiyoshi, but as far as I'm concerned she's an excellent writer and she gets a lot of great sounds, chords and textures out of that band. Then the GRP All Star Band has got a wonderful sound.

BH: How often does that band play though?

FF: I don't know, I don't know.

BH: If they're all together—

FF: Yeah, I think they just get together and record, and then that's the last you see of them. I don't know if they make in person —

BH: Yeah, I think most of those guys have individual careers that they're pursuing, you know.

FF: Then you have the Carnegie Hall band under the direction of Jon Faddis, the Lincoln Center Orchestra under the direction of Wynton Marsalis, these are perpetuating different

styles, like from Jelly Roll Morton to Louis Armstrong to Fats Waller to Duke Ellington, etcetera, etcetera, Basie, and they're sort of repertory orchestras.

BH: I think the Smithsonian has one as well.

FF: Smithsonian, yes, with Doug Harris, which we just saw him, not Doug Harris, Doug Richards, why do I say Doug Harris? Doug Richards, from VCU, down at the Smithsonian. Wonderful job.

BH: What do they call that band that he puts together?

FF: I'm not sure of the name of it.

BH: They do a lot of old, you know—

FF: Yeah, yeah, the traditional.

BH: I understand he has an insight to a lot of the original charts because they were at the Smithsonian.

FF: Yes, he does. He's the right person for that job. He does a wonderful job with that.

BH: So it's going on. You know it's still going on.

FF: Some bands around New York, you know Maria Schneider is a lady who has a kicking band and she does some wonderful writing.

BH: Is that, that's not Diva?

FF: No I don't think that's Diva, that's another.

BH: Yeah, that's an all girl, all woman, that's another.

MW: Doesn't John LaBarbara write for them?

BH: He may, I haven't heard that name.

FF: I think so, yeah.

MR: Can you tell us about writing for Joe Williams? You wrote a certain style for him, and what it was like to work with him when he was with the band?

FF: It was great working with him because he, like Sarah Vaughan, usually let me have free hand, free reign, and just let me have the lyrics and he'd sing them down for me, and give me an idea of basically the kind of backing he wanted, and let me go myself from there. 'Cause I used to pride myself on being able to really write some Basie type blues.

BH: And you did.

MR: I have that album with the arrangements right on the "Basie Swings" and the —

FF: Yeah and "Joe Williams Sings Basie Swings" yes, yes, that was— Thad Jones also did some wonderful work for Joe, as well as Ernie Wilkins. Ernie Wilkins, he wrote the big, the arrangement on the big hit "Every Day" and there was another one called "Five O'clock in the Morning."

BH: Do you know that that "Every Day" started out as a head tune. Do you remember when Joe Williams joined the band and we took that southern swing? And I remember because

we used to say a lot of the licks that Ernie put into "Every Day" we'd already like set those things, and he wrote them in.

FF: Right. And then there were two songs that were heads from "Jump City": "I Got a Gal"—"Roll 'Em Pete" and "Shake, Rattle and Roll." Not a note of music written for either of those full fledged arrangements. I mean the audience would never know the difference. That was going back to the old days in the best way possible — totally from the head. Then there was recording that we did, now this was, this was off the subject of Joe Williams, remember when they had the M Squad, that detective story on television? They wanted a theme for the M Squad and they came to me unfortunately, and they brought me a sketch of somebody from the studio had written this dumb sketch, and I was supposed to make something up. And it wasn't a blues, it was just like eight bars of some nonsense, and I said now what am I going to do with this? And I labored over this mess, and I tried to make something out of it and I just, man I'm just not one for taking ideas of others and turning them into something, especially when they, I can't use the word—

MW: Left handed?

MR: It's worse than that.

FF: So we got in the studio and they ran it down and it's, "well, I don't know, we're looking for something" — So Thad Jones, Frank Wess and I put our heads together and Thad did most of the work, it was "you play this note, you play this, and let's take this little riff and you play this." And he came out with the M Squad theme with not a note of music written, totally a head tune. [scats] Well that's what it was, that's how it started out.

BH: You know what's a direct rip off on that?

FF: What's that?

BH: "Thirty-three and a Third Detective" a direct rip off.

FF: Is that right?

MW: Naked Gun.

FF: Naked Gun, yeah right, what's his name?

BH: I don't know who did the arrangement on the thing.

MR: Followed pretty heavily, huh?

BH: All the way.

MW: I wanted to ask you something about that and have you just make a comment on this. Can you give us some of your insights, when you talk about head arrangements, with no written music, and people just doing it out of their own experience of knowing the music, somebody starting a riff and the next person automatically knows where that lays on the horn and how to pick that up in unison then how to split it into harmony, or the bari sax automatically knows to play a lower diatone line to that. Can you talk to us about how

FF: Well you have to go back to the call and response idea, you know? That's part of our oral history, right, the call and response. Okay, well in music, in jazz, the trumpets may set one riff, the saxophones will respond by filling in the blank spaces. The trumpets might say [scats] And that's like a—

MW: But it's like the two of them are having a conversation.

FF: Yeah, right, right.

BH: Like a man and a woman, you know? If the trumpets are playing something up high, and you want to have a response to that on a masculine level, and the trumpets are sounding like the female, then you come in and make your statement behind them to answer like, no you're not going to do that. And that's the kind of an attitude you have to have. Like when the trumpets say something, you gotta get in there and get your thing going, you know, and it's just like he says, the call and response. But to me it's always been the male/female type thing, you know, the female talks, the male answers, and I don't know, the reed section kind of mediates the —

MW: You know you're saying something here that I think is very rich. You know what you just said right now, the first thing, the response that it got from me and Monk is it made us laugh, because of the insight of it, you know the insight that you give the male/female thing, the call and response thing. Every time you talk about call and response I think of a choir and a preacher, you know? But the other thing I was saying is see so little of this is taught in schools.

MR: Hard to teach, though.

BH: That's one thing that Frank has been trying to do with this band is to go into schools and tell people how the thing was really done — not from a, well I won't say an educational standpoint, but from —

MW: You mean music theory.

BH: Yeah not from that theoretical standpoint but from the feeling standpoint. And we've been, well we have this particular thing that we do at Hampton University where all these little bands come in and they play their thing and Frank and a few of the other guys critique these bands. And they particularly hone in on the feeling that the kids are getting. Because that's the one thing that they do miss. I mean they're getting all this stuff in the schools but they don't get the basic, you've got to have a feeling to play this thing. You know, let's start to express ourselves, the way we feel. Not only what the notes are saying, but how you feel about those notes, you know? And we'd like to spread that around more, but it doesn't happen as often as we'd like.

MR: I think there's a big part of teaching that's sometimes left out is just dealing with hearing and playing something from in here where, instead of off a sheet of paper.

MW: You know Ruth? We were talking with Ruth and basically what she said was when you play these notes, these notes are expensive. The notes cost you something. You know there's an emotional price tag to those notes.

BH: That's right.

FF: Very well stated.

BH: You can't put it any better than that. And if anybody knows, she knows, cause you can hear her giving it out again.

MR: She told us some stories about traveling that were, something else.

BH: And she did an album with one of the greatest jazz bands in the history of this country as far as I was concerned, was the Thad Jones - Mel Lewis Band. And she did an album that was just killing.

FF: It really was. It still is.

BH: Do you have it?

MR: Yeah. I have to ask you about "Shiny Stockings." I mean that's a great piece. Can you remember how'd that thing start?

FF: It was a pair of shiny stockings.

MW: Tell us the story behind that.

FF: Well see now this involves my first wife and I'm not inclined to talk, speak too well of her.

MR: Tell us about the chart.

FF: Okay, the chart was inspired by my first wife putting on stockings. This was in 1954 BPH (before panty hose), when stockings were really stockings. You know and all the appendages, yes garter belts, I didn't want to say it. But and she used to put them on and the light would hit her legs in a certain way. And it just, the phrase "Shiny Stockings" just came to me, looking at this repeatedly, repeatedly, you know. Something happens long enough to you and you get an idea about it. And so I put it into a song. But the really significant part of the history of that song was that I labored over the arrangement, I made sure that every note was just right, in the right place. And the first time we rehearsed it was in Pep's Bar in Philadelphia. And we had come in that day and the band was tired and evil, and everybody wanted to get some rest and nobody felt like rehearsing. And I just can't for the life of me figure why Basie insisted on this rehearsal. But customarily we rehearsed the first day, the opening day in any club that was a week or two weeks or more, we rehearsed the first day of the engagement. Well this first day, no one felt like rehearsing and I brought "Shiny Stockings" in. And the way the guys felt was manifested in the way they played this song. And I said oh God, this will never be played because if something didn't sound good in rehearsal, Basie nixed it. It just wouldn't get played.

something there, he must have realized that, well the guys are all evil and tired, and they're not putting their hundred percent, but there's something in there. He must have. Because that's one of the few charts that I ever contributed that Basie years later came to me and said, "hey, Foss, that 'Shiny Stockings,'" he said, "you really put one down that time."

BH: That's exactly the way he would have said that too.

MW: And of course that's like a standard now. Everybody plays it everywhere. You know if you're like a college big band and you haven't played "Shiny Stockings" you don't know the repertoire.

MR: That must make you feel good, doesn't it.

FF: Certainly. Yes it does. It makes me feel very good.

MR: Like I think about guys trying to tell guitar players to do a certain thing. You're doing a swing tune and you say, "now do that Freddie Green thing." I mean that's such a contribution that's something to be really proud of.

MW: I did that in rehearsal today — to Steve Promise.

MR: Did he know what you were talking about?

MW: Yes.

MR: And you did a solo, what's that tune "Magic" that you played on?

BH: Yeah, that was a blues that Frank Wess, Frank Wess wrote that. That's what we used to call him—

FF: Still is his nickname.

MR: No kidding, I'll have to remember that when we see him.

BH: Yeah, and every now and then I got a chance to stand up from Frank. But that's a long time ago.

MW: I wanted to go back and ask you one thing, if you could elaborate on this. You talked about your times traveling to Europe. I would like to ask you if you can relate anything to the way that African Americans were treated in Europe. The stories that I've heard so far is that they were treated much better, and given real treatment like an artist as compared to some of the early years in jazz here, and I was kind of wondering if you could compare that to the way that we treat European orchestral conductors over here.

BH: Well I'm not completely aware of how they treat orchestral conductors over here, but I know for sure that we were welcomed to Europe in a different way. And they had a basic respect for jazz, especially during the '50's and '60's, that the Americans just didn't have. And that's when jazz was fading fast in this country. And you would go to Europe and everybody would know all about you. You know they'd know your whole history. And they'd be lining up for autographs outside the place like you know, like they do for

That thing about being treated more like an artist rather than just a musician, that's very true, very very true.

FF: They treated American jazz like a revered product from another land, as we treat European classical music here. And they realized early on that this was the classical music of America. And in most major cities at one time or another they had what you call the "radio bands" now that's hardly ever been heard of in the United States, the "radio band." We had television orchestras, The Tonight Show Orchestra, and Merv Griffin, and all people like that had bands, but radio bands? And even some of those radio bands are still in existence today. I just did a job with one of them last, back in November, it's called SGR, The South German Radio band. A wonderful group of musicians. I mean they know what the tradition is all about, and they are a bunch of swinging Europeans. And they've got this happening [snaps fingers] you know? I went there and I was right at home. So in answer to your question, the treatment of African Americans has been wonderful and going back to the days when the United States did not treat us as well.

BH: So wonderful that a lot of people were persuaded to move there.

FF: That right. Ben Webster, Don Byas, Coleman Hawkins. Now some have come back, you know Slide Hampton lived over there for years. I think Johnny Griffin still lives over there.

BH: How about Art Farmer?

FF: Art Farmer, as far as I know, is still a resident of Vienna, but I don't know if he came back or not. And there are some others like —

MW: Ed Thigpen?

FF: Ed Thigpen, yes, and of course Kenny Clarke, the late Kenny Clarke, the late Leo Wright who played with Dizzy, and there were some great musicians who got jobs in the studio. Herb Geller, an alto saxophonist, white American, he went over there and so did Sal Nistico.

BH: Sal Nistico.

MR: He's from Utica, you know?

FF: James Williams.

MW: Bad Upstate New Yorkers, boy. There's some energy around here.

MR: Yeah.

FF: That has persisted down through the –

MR: Nick Brignola.

FF: Nick Brignola, Sammy Noto, of course the Mangione brothers.

MR: Steve Gadd.

FF: Steve Gadd, yeah, around the Utica-Schenectady-Syracuse-Rochester area, a whole lot of

MR: The pasta did it, right?

FF: Maybe so.

MW: I wanted to ask you a question. Tell us a little bit about your group, The Loud Minority.

FF: Ah, The Loud Minority. Undisciplined, unbridled passion, and rage — happy rage. That was the most undisciplined group of men and women. I had two ladies in and out of that band — and instrumentalists, not vocalists. I had male and female vocalists, but lady instrumentalists — Janice Robinson the trombonist, and Sharon Freeman, a French horn and pianist. But we were characterized by our inability to play soft, or for lorng. I didn't plan it that way it just happened. And everybody was a soloist. We didn't omit anybody from the solo category. And there were some who weren't that proficient at soloing but I insisted that they just try to get it together. And there were even some who soloed on songs that they had no business playing on them. This one guy played trumpet. He should never have been playing "Shiny Stockings" but he did it, he played a solo in "Shiny Stockings" and every time he got [snaps fingers] this from the audience. Well, what can I do? I can't take it away from him, but they would listen to my wife, Cecelia, but they wouldn't listen to me. If I'd cuss them out, you know, I'd do the old Illinois Jacquet on them "y'all sounded like—y'all didn't do the —" But one set they would get together and they would be perfectly together, and the next set, the unbridled, undisciplined rage would return.

BH: That's the first time I heard it put like that, Foss.

FF: Yeah, I got several, I got a whole bunch of fugitives from The Loud Minority infiltrating the world out there. One of these days we're going to take over.

MR: On that note, I know you guys have to get up early, and I wish we could talk all night.

BH: Oh, hell, let's talk all night, let's talk all night. You got us started here now.

FF: We only scratched the surface of jazz, I mean—

BH: You didn't let us tell any Joe Williams stories.

MR: Well let me hear the Joe Williams story.

MW: We got to get a Joe Williams story.

BH: I'm only kidding.

FF: Well there's one Joe Williams story that comes to mind, where he was singing this torchy ballad, you know, and in the old days in the little cabarets, male vocalists, and female vocalists especially, some of them would like jump up on the piano to sing the ballad and take the mic with them and jump up on the piano and cross their ankles and sing, and everybody would just groove along with it. This one time, I don't know where we were but Joe Williams tried to jump up on that piano and didn't make it. And he tried again and again, and still didn't make it. And so Frank Wess, Frank Wess has got a laugh that

forever. And he started laughing and it was infectious, the whole band started, so Joe finally gave up and then stood up and sang the song like he should have in the first place.

MR: And Joe will be watching that, that's good. Anything else you want to add for us?

BH: Well I only remember one thing in particular about Joe. Joe came into this band, I think the day after Christmas in 1954. He and Sonny Payne came in on the same day. And they started being roommates. And you have never seen an odder couple than those two, you know, I mean the stories that came from that union were enough to fill a book, and I mean I could like say all night long about the things that they did that were awesomely funny. But Joe transformed this band from like a great band that was working but not making a lot of money, into a great band that was working and making a lot of money. That's how, he really did that much. Because once we recorded "Every Day" and what was that "Roll 'em Pete," and "Teach Me Tonight" — all that stuff seemed like it just hit all at once, you know, and all of a sudden we were working in all these places and the crowd was there you know and we were making money and Basie was happy and the band was happy having fun. We weren't making any money but, the band was happy, you know.

FF: And the words Count Basie-Joe Williams were magic. There was a guaranteed full house, lines around the corner. Count Basie-Joe Williams.

BH: That's it. That was it. It just transformed the whole thing.

FF: In the late 50's.

MW: And so what you're saying there is between musicians, even after your skill levels have reached a point where people don't even question the skills anymore, still there are special times where there is chemistry.

BH: Oh yeah, definitely. And that was it. The band and Joe Williams came together at that particular moment and it was history after that, it was just history.

MW: Can I ask you one last question? Did you know at that time, could you sense at that time, very early on, that, this is going to be in the *Grove Dictionary of Jazz* later.

BH: No, no, we weren't thinking, I don't think we were thinking in a historical perspective when that happened. We were more into the selfish mode about what does this mean to us in terms of what we were playing now.

FF: I kind of had a feeling that musical history was being made.

BH: Well after the record I did, you know? Because I'd be walking down the street and all I'd hear is "did you say I got a lot to learn" it was all over the place, you know, everywhere I'd go, and then "Every Day" I said damn, we're, we're everywhere now. I said I'm part of something here, and—

FF: I was very happy to be a part of it.

BH: Yeah. And I don't know, it was just a feeling, especially for me, that Sonny Payne hit the thing right on the head that we needed right at that point. More so than Joe Williams to me. Although it really didn't ring into me on Joe Williams until I heard those records being played all over the place. But Sonny, like he had a knack for moving this band at that time.

FF: Plus he was visual.

BH: Yeah, he was very visual.

FF: You know the thing with the juggling the sticks, throwing the sticks up and catching them and hitting right on a given beat, and this was, when you catch an audience with a visual extravaganza as well as a aural or musical—

BH: And there we were, two of the, you know—

FF: And Joe and Sonny were two of the most colorful characters in the band, which was full of colorful characters. Everybody had a story. And then when we acquired the likes of Snooky Young to play lead trumpet, and there was Joe Newman and —

BH: I think that was the final piece when Snooky was —

FF: That was the icing on the cake. And that was arguably the greatest of all Basie bands. That was the New Testament band. The Old Testament band being the band from the late 30's and early 40's. In the late 40's it wasn't such, it was good but it wasn't—

BH: It wasn't as polished as the band in the late 50's.

FF: Right. We developed into a precision, a slick, precision, east coast jazz machine. But still, lots of feeling, the feeling never left. So the precision and the polish came, and the feeling, you know it just steamrolled over people. And with Joe Williams and Sonny Payne there too, and Marshall Royal playing lead alto, I mean he was, see the voice of the band was Marshall Royal, Snooky Young and Henry Coker, the lead players. And together they gave the band one hell-fired voice.

BH: Yes they did. You're making me cry for it.

FF: And then the Freddie Green metronomic but still loose, happy rhythm, and Eddie Jones, who acquired a technique of walking the bass that was just phenomenal. And then Sonny Payne with the power that he gave to it. The All American Rhythm Section of the late 50's. And hey—

BH: It was a great time to be alive.

FF: It really was. And a great time to be young, you know, like I was in my early 20's, from 24 until about 32 years of age. That was right in the meat of party time.

BH: You know when you tend to think of old time bands as being old musicians, you know. But what was really happening was that these bands were young bands. Even Basie's first band, that was young guys out there, you know, doing that stuff. And you tend to think of

were playing, but they weren't old cats. Those were young cats playing the music of their time.

MR: What's this thing about Papa Foss? I heard that song the other day.

FF: That's what the thing about Papa— it's a pianist by the name of Danny Mixon who played with me in my small group and he's a Loud Minority so you know he's Spacetakovitch, like we all were, and he composed this song called "Papa Foss" [scats]. So he didn't have any lyrics to it. So my wife Cecelia and I got together and we put the lyrics to this song. and I sold Carmen Bradford on the idea of singing it. And of course it put me out front, you know, "standing out in front of it is Papa Foss, been out in front of it is Papa Foss." So it showed me off in a very good light. So and I was very happy that she agreed to sing it. And we got recorded, and it's in the annals so to speak.

MR: Yeah, they've been playing it in Syracuse.

FF: Is that right?

MR: Yeah, they've got a good jazz station there.

FF: Well that's good to know. We don't play it anymore now that Carmen's not with the band, because that was her song, I mean, she put something on it that I don't think anyone else could. And of course we had a trumpet battle between Bob Ojeda and the very brilliant Melton Mustafa, and they just took it to great levels.

BH: I forgot that part.

FF: Yeah it was something else. But people don't call me that too much anymore. Thankfully. I'll just be happy to be called "Foss."

MR: Well we want to thank you gentlemen, and Frank Foster currently leading the Basie orchestra on tenor and soprano sax, and Bill Hughes holding down the bass trombone chair. It's been a real pleasure talking to you and thanks a lot for your stories.

FF: It's been our pleasure too.

MW: I think the Basie band is in good hands.

BH: Thank you very much, I appreciate it.